

Conor Shields sending frequent crosses from the left, while Farukh or Irfan Yadwad tested the goalkeeper.

But minutes after the cooling break, Mohammedan counter-attacked. Vanlalzuidika Chhakchhuak switched play with a long ball from the right flank, and Lalremhsanga Fanai beat Chennaiyin's goalkeeper Samik Mitra to find the breakthrough. The local crowd was stunned into silence, as if struck by a bolt of lightning, as Mohammedan's camp celebrated the strike.

The roar of the local fans returned after the second-half whistle, with Chennaiyin's 12th man trying to inspire a comeback — one that almost came through Brambilla in second-half stoppage time.

However, Vanlalzuidika and Gaurav Bora's joint header, just inches in front of the goal-line, ensured that Chennaiyin failed to win its first ISL home game for the 10th consecutive season.

An evening that had begun with a mountain of hope for Chennai's home side ended with fans holding their heads in their hands and frowns on their faces. Meanwhile, the Black Panthers were the last to leave the dressing room, after a rousing celebration of hunting down its first-ever prey in the ISL.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee

Cuadrat leaves East Bengal

In a world of intense competition, nothing succeeds like success. Some teams in the ISL realise this the hard way, as they are unable to find the recipe for success. One of them is certainly East Bengal. The 104-year-old club joined the league in 2020 but has since found fortune forsaking it. Failures bring about frustration among fans, while the management axes coaches to gloss over the team's shortcomings. The latest casualty in this regard is Spanish gaffer Carles Cuadrat (right), who lost his job after his side suffered

its third successive loss this season.

Cuadrat helped East Bengal end a 12-year-long title drought by shepherding it to the Kalinga Super Cup title at the beginning of this year. This sparked euphoria among millions of its fans, who felt that the Super Cup crown would be the harbinger of hope.

With its city cousin Mohun Bagan Super Giant making it a habit of winning laurels in the ISL (by adding the Cup and League Shield to its trophy cabinet in successive years), East Bengal had a lot to do to catch up. But with three successive losses at the start of this season, hope soon gave way to despair.

Having helped Bengaluru FC to the ISL title in 2019, Cuadrat was looked up to as the saviour as East Bengal became desperate for success. But the magic wand that he seemed to possess appeared to lose its power, as the club hit the doldrums right from the start. Two successive wins in the group league stage of Durand Cup 2024 were its only achievements before

succumbing to a string of defeats, starting with the



Shock treatment: Local fans were stunned into silence, as if struck by a bolt of lightning, when Mohammedan Sporting scored its first goal, the only one of the match. FSDL/ISL MEDIA

quarterfinal loss in the Indian football calendar's season-opener. The slide continued in the ISL, as it failed to recall the form and formula that gave it so much to aspire to last season.

Cuadrat could only depart reminiscing about the good times. "Thank you @eastbengal_fc for all the special moments we have lived together. It has been an Honour & Pride to represent such a great Club with such an important Legacy behind..."

From the very first moment, I understood what it means to represent a Club with so much History and so many Fans who love it, and I wish with all my Heart to the #amagofans and all the big & community many Successes and Joys in the Future...

Grateful to Indian football for giving us the opportunity to lead two winning projects, to win @indiansuperleague for BFC in 2019 & Super Cup for EBFC in 2024," Cuadrat posted on his X (formerly Twitter) account after saying goodbye to East Bengal.

Amitabha Das Sharma

